



## HOW-TO GUIDE

# Plane Detailing

Every aircraft service we sell, step by step, with the exact product for each one. The rules page is not optional reading. On aircraft, some mistakes are safety issues.

## The Kit

Exact products. Anything in **red** is not on the shelf yet, see the last page.

| PRODUCT                              | WHAT IT IS                     | WHAT IT'S FOR                                                       |
|--------------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aero Cosmetics Wash Wax ALL          | Aircraft-approved wash and wax | The main wash. Works wet or waterless and leaves protection behind. |
| Aero Cosmetics Degreaser             | Aircraft-safe degreaser        | Belly, exhaust streaks, and oil residue.                            |
| Plexus Plexiglass Cleaner            | Acrylic-safe cleaner           | Windows and canopies only. Nothing else touches acrylic.            |
| Nuvite or Met-All Polish             | Aluminum polish                | Bare polished aluminum only. Not for painted surfaces.              |
| Marine Maxx Ceramic Coating          | Ceramic coating                | The Full Ceramic Package.                                           |
| Painter's tape and plastic sheeting  | Masking                        | Pitot tubes, static ports, and sensors. Non-negotiable.             |
| Soft microfiber towels, lots of them | Drying and buffing             | Aircraft finishes mark easily. Always fresh towels.                 |
| Step ladder or rolling platform      | Access                         | Tails and fuselage tops. Never climb on the aircraft itself.        |
| Respirator and safety glasses        | Safety gear                    | Aluminum polishing throws fine black dust you should not breathe.   |

## Rules That Don't Change

These apply to every single job. Read them once, follow them always.

- **You are working on someone's aircraft. Get explicit permission and ask about restrictions before you touch anything.** If the owner has a mechanic, it's worth a quick word with them too.
- **Mask the pitot tube, static ports, and any external sensors before water goes anywhere near the aircraft.** Water in these causes false instrument readings. This is a flight safety issue, not a cosmetic one.
- **Never use household glass cleaner on aircraft windows.** Ammonia crazes acrylic, which means a spiderweb of permanent cracks and a window that has to be replaced. Plexus only.
- **Never spray water into engine inlets, exhaust, wheel wells, brakes, or control surface hinges.** Water sits in bearings and causes corrosion.
- **Static wicks are fragile and expensive.** Those little rods on the trailing edges. Don't grab them, lean on them, or drag a towel across them.
- **Only stand where you're told you can stand.** Wings have designated walkways. Standing anywhere else can dent the skin.
- **Never polish painted surfaces with aluminum polish.** Nuvite and Met-All are for bare polished aluminum only, they'll destroy paint.
- **Don't let anything, tools, rags, caps, get left behind in or on the aircraft.** Loose objects are a genuine flight hazard. Count what you brought and count it back out.

## Wash

\$250 to \$300 ballpark, custom quote · single-engine piston · about 3 to 4 hours

A full exterior wash: fuselage, wings, tail, and belly, plus windows. No polish, no compounding.

### 1 Talk to the owner and mask up

- Confirm what you can and can't touch, and where you're allowed to stand.
- Mask the pitot tube, static ports, and any sensors with tape and plastic. Do this every single time.
- Walk around and photograph any existing paint chips, crazing, or damage.

## 2 Belly first

- **Aero Cosmetics Degreaser** on the belly and the exhaust streaks behind the cowlings.
- This is the dirtiest part, so it gets done first and separately, before your clean towels are anywhere near it.
- Agitate gently with a soft brush and wipe off.

## 3 Wash the aircraft top down

- **Aero Cosmetics Wash Wax ALL**, mixed per the bottle, using soft mitts and plenty of clean towels.
- Top of the fuselage, then the wings, then down the sides, tail last.
- Work in sections and wipe each one before it dries.
- If water is restricted at the hangar, this product works waterless, spray on and wipe off with clean towels, changing towels often.

## 4 Leading edges and bugs

- Bug residue on the leading edges takes a longer dwell, not more scrubbing.
- Soak, wait, wipe. Scrubbing hard on a leading edge will scratch the paint.

## 5 Windows, carefully

- **Plexus Plexiglass Cleaner** only, sprayed onto a clean soft microfiber, then wiped in straight lines.
- Never wipe a dry window, grit will scratch it. Rinse the surface first if there's any dust.
- Never use a dirty or gritty towel on acrylic. When in doubt, get a fresh one.

## 6 Dry, unmask, and check

- Dry with clean towels, paying attention to seams and around fasteners where water sits.
- Remove every piece of masking. Double check the pitot and static ports are clear.
- Walk the aircraft and count your tools and rags back out.

**Watch out.** If you leave masking on a pitot tube or static port, the aircraft's airspeed and altitude readings will be wrong in flight. Removing all masking and confirming it is the most important thing you do on a plane.

### Done when

- ☐ Belly and exhaust streaks are clean.
- ☐ No streaks or water spots on the paint.
- ☐ Windows are perfectly clear with no new scratches and no haze.
- ☐ Every piece of masking is off and the ports are confirmed clear.
- ☐ No tools, towels, or trash left anywhere on or in the aircraft.

## Wash & Polish

\$500 to \$600 ballpark, custom quote · about 6 to 9 hours

Everything in the Wash, plus oxidation removal and polishing. On bare aluminum aircraft this is the service that brings the shine back.

### 1 Full wash first

- Every step of the Wash service, including masking.

### 2 Work out what you're polishing

- Painted surface or bare polished aluminum? They are completely different jobs and different products.
- If you are not certain, ask the owner. Getting this wrong is expensive.

### 3 Bare aluminum

- **Nuvite or Met-All Polish** with the appropriate grade, starting with the least aggressive that works.
- Respirator and safety glasses on. This throws fine black aluminum dust.
- Small sections, keep the pad moving, and wipe off the black residue as you go.
- Work along the airflow direction, not across it.

#### 4 Painted surfaces

- A light polish suitable for aircraft paint only. Aircraft paint is often thinner than automotive paint.
- Stay off decals, registration numbers, and any placards, they will lift.
- Never use aluminum polish here.

#### 5 Clean up the residue

- Polish residue collects in every seam, rivet line, and gap.
- Go over the whole aircraft with clean towels and a soft detail brush. Residue left in seams looks careless and can corrode.

**Watch out.** Aluminum polishing dust is fine, black, and gets everywhere. Wear a respirator, and keep it well away from open engine cowlings, brakes, and the cabin.

**Tip.** This is slow, physical work and the reason the price is what it is. Quote by the condition of the aircraft, not by its size alone.

#### Done when

- ☐ Even shine with no dull patches or swirl trails.
- ☐ No polish residue in seams, rivet lines, or around fasteners.
- ☐ No polish on decals, placards, or registration numbers.
- ☐ All masking removed and ports confirmed clear.

## Wash, Polish & Wax

\$750 to \$900 ballpark, custom quote · about 8 to 11 hours

Everything in the Wash & Polish, plus a protective wax layer to hold the finish and make the next wash easier.

#### 1 Wash and polish first

- Complete both fully.

#### 2 Apply protection

- **Aero Cosmetics Wash Wax ALL** leaves a wax layer as part of the wash, so a final pass over the whole aircraft builds that protection up evenly.
- Thin and even, buffed off with clean towels.
- Work in sections so nothing sits too long.

#### 3 Extra attention on the leading edges

- Leading edges, the top of the fuselage, and the tail take the most weather and sun.
- A second pass here is worth it and the owner will notice it lasts longer.

#### 4 Final walk-around

- Check every seam and fastener for residue.
- Confirm all masking is off and the ports are clear.
- Count tools and rags back out.

**Watch out.** Keep wax off the windows and off the walkway areas of the wing. A slippery wing walk is dangerous for whoever boards next.

#### Done when

- ☐ Even protection with no residue in seams or around rivets.
- ☐ Windows clean and wax-free.
- ☐ Wing walk areas are not slippery.
- ☐ All masking removed, ports clear, nothing left behind.

## Full Ceramic Package

**\$1,800 to \$2,200** ballpark, custom quote · often **2 to 3 days**

Wash, full polish, then a ceramic coating instead of wax. The longest-lasting protection offered, and it makes future washes far quicker.

#### 1 Wash and full polish

- Every step of Wash & Polish. The coating locks in whatever is underneath.

#### 2 Confirm the coating suits the surface

- Check the coating is appropriate for the surface, painted or bare aluminum, and that the owner is happy with it going on.
- If the aircraft is on a maintenance program, it's worth confirming with their mechanic.

#### 3 Prep the surface

- Wipe everything down with the prep wipe or isopropyl solution to strip polishing oils.
- The coating will not bond over oils. This step decides whether the job lasts a year or a month.

#### 4 Coat in small sections

- **Marine Maxx Ceramic Coating** or an equivalent aviation-suitable coating, per the bottle.
- Small sections, cross-hatch, watch for the flash, buff off with a fresh towel and check with a second.
- Work in a hangar out of wind and direct sun. Dust landing on curing coating is a real problem.

#### 5 Cure and hand over

- Keep the aircraft in the hangar and dry for the full cure time on the label.
- Give the owner written care instructions and tell them the cure time before the job starts.

#### 6 Final safety walk

- Every piece of masking off, pitot and static ports confirmed clear.
- Every tool, towel, and applicator accounted for and out of the aircraft.

**Watch out.** This is the highest-value job we offer and the one with the most ways to go wrong. If anything is unclear about the aircraft, stop and ask the owner rather than guessing.

#### Done when

- ☐ Even coating, no high spots, streaks, or rainbow patches.
- ☐ Water beads and sheets off cleanly.
- ☐ No coating on windows, placards, or in seams.
- ☐ All masking removed, both ports confirmed clear, and confirmed a second time.
- ☐ Nothing left behind on or in the aircraft.
- ☐ Owner has written care instructions and knows the cure time.

## Still Need To Buy

Aircraft work is quoted per job. The masking supplies and Plexus are the two things you should never be without.

| ITEM                                | WHY                                                                       | ROUGHLY |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| Aero Cosmetics Wash Wax ALL         | The core product. You already buy this brand                              | \$40-70 |
| Aero Cosmetics Degreaser            | Bellies and exhaust streaks need it on every job                          | \$25-40 |
| Plexus Plexiglass Cleaner           | The only safe window product. A crazed window is a very expensive mistake | \$15-20 |
| Nuvite or Met-All Polish            | Only if you take on bare polished aluminum aircraft                       | \$40-80 |
| Painter's tape and plastic sheeting | Masking ports and sensors. Never run out of this                          | \$15-25 |
| Respirator and safety glasses       | Required for aluminum polishing dust                                      | \$30-60 |

|                                        |                                                          |          |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| <b>Step ladder or rolling platform</b> | For tails and fuselage tops. Never stand on the aircraft | \$80-250 |
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